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Collaborative Writing

IB 514: Scientific Writing

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Dissertation Manuscripts as Collaborative Efforts

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- **You own the draft.** As first author, you are responsible for maintaining *momentum* on the manuscript and for ensuring its *integrity*.
- **Advisors may be a co-author, don't expect them to be editors.** They may choose to revise and redirect, but the *intellectual initiative* should come from you.
- **Co-authorship is not automatic.** Contribution, not relationship or seniority, should determine authorship; clarify expectations *before* writing begins.
- **Co-authors have competing priorities.** You, your advisor, and your collaborators need not share the same *incentives*.

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Tools for Collaborative Writing

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Choose tools that match your collaboration needs

MS Word / Apple Pages Share via email or cloud storage. Well-known; track changes; offline editing; weak for complex or equation-heavy formatting.

Google Docs Real-time cloud-based editing. Low barrier to entry; suggesting mode; comment threads; best for early drafts or non- $\text{\LaTeX}$ collaborators.

Overleaf Cloud-based $\text{\LaTeX}$ editor with real-time collaboration. Comment threads; full revision history; Git sync; the standard for $\text{\LaTeX}$ manuscripts with multiple authors.

Git / GitHub Version-controlled repositories; cloud-based. Full audit trail; branching; ideal for $\text{\LaTeX}$ and code; not real-time; steeper learning curve.

Practical Rule: Agree on a tool *before* writing begins. Mid-project migrations are time-consuming and introduce errors.

File Versioning

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If you're not using version control software (Git)...

File Naming Ambiguous filenames are a form of technical debt. Adopt a convention and enforce it from day one.

<i>Avoid</i>	<code>draft_final_v2_JSmith_revised_FINAL.doc</code>
<i>Better</i>	<code>2025-11-14_manuscript_v07.doc</code>
<i>Better</i>	<code>manuscript_v07.doc</code>

Versioning Conventions

- Use **ISO dates** (YYYY-MM-DD) or **sequential version numbers** (v01, v02) — not both. Append commenting author initials.
- **Tag submission-ready versions** explicitly (v_submitted, v_R1)
- **Don't delete old versions** — archive them in an /archive subfolder

Comment and Annotation Discipline

- Resolve or explicitly defer all comments before circulating a new draft
- Use GitHub Issues or margin note comment threads to track unresolved questions and decisions
- Do not leave unresolved comments at submission — some journal portals expose tracked changes to reviewers

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Establishing Norms and Expectations

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Collaboration is Communication

Most conflicts stem from unmet unstated expectations

Clarify at the start:

- **Authorship:** Confirm whether your advisor will be last author and who is to be offered (the right to decline) authorship.
- **Level of involvement:** Will advisor/collaborators co-write sections, provide key figures, or provide feedback on drafts?
- **Escalation path:** Who has final say on journal choice, framing, interpretation, etc.? What happens if co-authors disagree?
- **Primary channel:** email, Slack, GitHub Issues — consider one platform for decisions, one for quick questions.
- **Response expectations:** what is a reasonable turnaround for draft review (1 week? 3 weeks?) and for quick questions (48 hours?).
- **Meeting cadence:** regular check-ins vs. milestone-driven meetings — both have costs and benefits.

Decision documentation: For large collaborations; all substantive decisions recorded in a shared log (email thread, shared doc, etc.)

Common Issues

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Common Friction Points

Advisor rewrites your draft: Treat as mentorship; study the changes; ask for rationale on substantive edits.

Co-author delays for weeks: Set a gentle deadline when providing updated draft — “*Could you get it back to me by X.*”

Co-authors disagree: Raise the conflict openly; do not triangulate between them; request a joint discussion.

A Common Failure Mode

Decisions made verbally in hallway conversations or lab meetings that are not recorded. Three months later, co-authors remember different outcomes.

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Resolving Disagreements

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Identify the Type of Disagreement First

Type	Example	Possible Resolution Pathways
Scientific	Disagreement over statistical model choice or interpretation of results	Resolve with evidence; consider additional analyses; consult a neutral expert
Framing	Disagreement over how to position paper's contribution	Consult target journal scope; summarize framing of comparable studies
Stylistic	Disagreement over sentence-level writing choices	Defer to the lead author; style is not worth extended negotiation
Interpersonal	Conflict rooted in prior relationship dynamics, credit concerns, or workload resentment	Address directly and early; do not let it contaminate scientific decisions

- Separate *positions* (what someone wants) from *interests* (why they want it) — interests are usually reconcilable
- Put manuscript's quality and reader's needs at the center of dispute
- Seek advice from neutral party (e.g., committee member) if direct resolution is failing

Hierarchy and Power Imbalance

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Common Sources of Imbalance

- **Career stage:** harder for student to push back on a advisors framing choices, even when student is domain expert
- **Disciplinary norms:** fields may have incompatible assumptions about authorship order, target journal status, publication timeline
- **Publication pressure:** misaligned incentives around when and where to publish can fracture teams

Power Differentials Are Structural, Not Personal

Collaborations can involve genuine differences in career vulnerability and publication pressure. Ignoring these dynamics does not neutralize them.

Protective Strategies

- Document your contributions in writing as work proceeds — do not rely on memory or goodwill at submission time
- Raise authorship expectations explicitly and early, before significant work has been invested
- Consider drafting the *Authorship Contributions* statement early

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Dividing and Tracking Contributions

Ambiguity about responsibility is a project risk

Task Delegation Principles

- **Assign ownership, not just involvement** — one person is responsible for each deliverable, even if others contribute
- **Be explicit about scope:** “draft the methods section” is a task; “help with methods” is not
- **Revisit assignments** as the project evolves — initial task maps rarely survive contact with data
- **Distinguish writing tasks from research tasks:** the person who ran the analysis may not be the best person to write it up, and vice versa

Contribution Tracking Tools

Google Sheets Simple shared task list with owner, status, and deadline columns — low barrier, universally accessible.

GitHub Issues Create tasks with milestone tracking; integrates directly with version-controlled repositories.

Asana/Trello/Notion Visual project boards suited to larger or longer-running collaborations.

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The Authorship Conversation

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When to Have It

Early — ideally before data collection begins, certainly before writing starts. Revisit at submission. (Conversations become exponentially harder once significant effort has been invested.)

What to Establish

- Who will be an author vs. acknowledged contributor?
- What is the expected authorship order and on what basis?
- What happens if contributions change substantially during project?
- Who is the senior and the corresponding author?
- What is the plan if a co-author becomes unresponsive before submission?

Avoid

- **Gift authorship:** including advisor/collaborator who did not contribute substantially/intellectually
- **Ghost authorship:** omitting those who contributed substantially
- **Retroactive negotiation:** changing authorship order after submission without full co-author agreement

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Collaborative writing is a skill that is eased by intentionality.

Key Takeaways

- Choose tools and establish norms early
- Communicate openly about expectations and contributions
- Address conflicts directly and with the manuscript's quality in mind
- Document major decisions and contributions openly